like the rest of the world, was simple. There was school cricket. Then district level, followed by college level, university level and then first-class. Then the national level. It was straight and simple.

Nowadays, as the demands of international cricket have changed, we will have to pivot our preferences and facilitate a change in the way the game is organized for our kids. We will have to change the way they are schooled so that young lads learn cricket from the ground up. It shouldn't be the case that a player begins re-establishing his basics once he's part of the Pakistan team. He shouldn't be picked out of the rough. He should be a polished diamond by the time he's ready to enter the big league.

It was all so different in my early days in cricket. When I began playing with the very legends I would dream about – of course, I was nervous as hell playing with them – the seniors used to take care of you, like big brothers do. Yes, there was dressing-room politics, but it was lateral, not vertical: senior versus senior, junior versus junior, not senior versus junior. Yes, there were rivalries within the team. But we would leave it all behind when we came down on the field. Once we had laced up our boots and were set to play, the unit would stick together. And by the way, the lack of media attention, especially the narcissism-driven social media, made people more focused too.

Imagine the greatness I was exposed to. Saeed Anwar. Ramiz Raja. Saleem Malik. Ijaz Ahmed. Aamer Sohail. Moin Khan. Rashid Latif. Inzamam-ul-Haq. Wasim Akram. Waqar Younis. This was the line-up I started playing with. Shoaib Akhtar, Saqlain Mushtaq and I were the lucky ones, the last of the lot who played with the old-school greats.

But as all these stars faded away, Pakistan's fortunes started dwindling on the field. In the dressing room, it was worse: there were no role models. And at the nets, a disaster was unfolding – the talent pool was drying up.

Back in the day, it used to be easy to play for Pakistan. It was first-class cricket where you made your bones. It was there that quality mattered. People knew who the best players were, across the board, across cities and clubs. First-class cricket was even covered aggressively by the national broadcaster and press. By the time you arrived on the international stage, you were already established nationally. Your reputation preceded you. That's all gone now.

I said as much to the BBC, about talent drying up. Again, I was quoted out of context by local media in Pakistan – clearly not just an Indian trait – that there is no local talent emerging from within this current system. Why? Because the current system is flawed. Why? Because a youngster who is coming into the game doesn't have the facilities he needs at the grass-roots level.

Consider this – only when a youngster has been picked for the Pakistan team does he start training. Training to eat. Training to field. Training to train! With all due respect to the managers and experts at the PCB – and most of them don't deserve much respect – there is no time to train when you've arrived at the international level. At that stage, it's all about performance. It's about excelling and peaking, not learning. Yes, you probably have to unlearn a shot or two, but it's not a stage to pick up new skills. The international level is where you have to harness the skills you already possess. But our system is such that youngsters pick up things *after* they are inducted into the national team, not before. The PCB has made the system run backwards.

Also, nowadays the incentive for becoming a cricketer has changed for some – and not just in